

Trench A — Mosaic floor

Excavation Report 2024 — Fake Museum of Example Antiquities

Trench A was opened on the eastern terrace at Ancient Messene (Αρχαία Μεσσήνη) and measured 6.0 by 4.5 metres. At a depth of 1.2 metres the excavators reached a mosaic floor with marine motifs: two dolphins flanking a trident, executed in black, white and ochre tesserae of roughly 1 cm. The floor is dated to the second century AD on the basis of the pottery in the bedding layer.

Twelve fragments of the mosaic border were lifted for conservation. The destruction layer above the floor contained burnt roof tiles and the marble head catalogued as FME-0001, which was recovered 40 cm above the mosaic surface.

Οι ψηφίδες είναι από τοπικό ασβεστόλιθο και υαλόμαζα.

Trench B — Byzantine cistern

Trench B lay 18 metres north of Trench A and exposed a Byzantine cistern built of rubble masonry bonded with lime mortar containing crushed brick. The interior was lined with two coats of hydraulic plaster, still preserved to a height of 1.8 metres.

The fill produced coarse Byzantine cooking ware, an iron nail concentration, and three gold coins of Justinian I, one of which is catalogued as FME-0008. The cistern went out of use in the late sixth century AD, when it was deliberately backfilled.

No Roman material was found below the cistern floor, which suggests the structure was cut into virgin soil rather than into an earlier building.

Conservation notes

Conservation work carried out in the 2024 season:

1. Marble head FME-0001. Surface soiling was reduced with deionised water and a soft brush. The fracture at the neck was consolidated with a 5% solution of acrylic resin in acetone. The burnt area on the left cheek was left untreated, since the burning is evidence of the destruction event and must remain legible.
2. Bronze strigil FME-0002. Active chloride corrosion was stabilised with benzotriazole and the object is now stored at 35% relative humidity.
3. Storeroom climate. The main storeroom is held at 20 °C and 55% relative humidity. A data logger recorded two excursions above 65% in August 2024.

Η συντήρηση πραγματοποιήθηκε στο εργαστήριο του μουσείου.